

TELECOM MARKET INTELLIGENCE — MONTHLY PULSE

Bulgaria Telecommunications Market

June 2026 — Competitive Intensity Brief

Run date: 2026-06-09

Operators covered: Vivacom · A1 Bulgaria · Yettel Bulgaria

Research window: Last 90 days (March–June 2026)

Year So Far

All three operators opened 2026 in a coordinated price-rise posture — the second consecutive year of inflation-linked fee increases — while mobile subscriber counts continue a slow structural decline (−0.4% YoY to ~7.98M at end-2024). The dominant dynamic is revenue-over-volume: operators are accepting churn in exchange for higher ARPU, supported by bundled fixed-mobile-TV convergence and state-backed fibre capex. The structural event shaping the year is e&'s late-2024 majority acquisition of Yettel and CETIN, which injected fresh capital and raised the competitive stakes on 5G infrastructure spending.

Last 90 Days

DIRECTIONAL VERDICT

Stable — coordinated price rises and symmetric fibre capex are suppressing head-to-head retail competition; the primary battleground has shifted to infrastructure quality and bundle depth rather than price.

- **Price increase (market-wide)** — A1 and Yettel both raised subscription fees ~9.5% in 2026; Vivacom raised by ~4.5%. Second consecutive year of inflation-linked increases, now treated as an annual norm by all three operators. CRC investigation opened but no enforcement action yet. ([Novinite](#), 2025–2026)
- **Bundle promotions** — Vivacom running fibre + EON TV bundles from BGN 16–25/month; A1 fibre from BGN 10–15/month; Yettel 5G Home from BGN 8.99–15.49/month in promotional periods. Competition is on convergence depth, not headline price cuts. ([4stogo.com](#), 2026)
- **A1 Group Q1 2026 earnings** — Group EBITDA +4.6%, international service revenues +11.5%. Bulgaria explicitly cited as a key contributor offsetting Austrian weakness. A1 has strong incentive to defend Bulgarian market position. ([Finanzwire](#), 2026-04-21)
- **Subscriber erosion continues** — Mobile subscriptions fell 0.4% in 2024; CRC attributes part of the revenue drop to lower EU-mandated wholesale voice termination rates, not retail weakness — retail pricing power remains intact. ([Novinite](#), 2026)
- **Spectrum — 900/1800 MHz consolidation complete** — CRC assigned remaining unused 900 MHz and 1800 MHz assets to all three operators,

completing the refarming of legacy 2G/3G spectrum into flexible 4G/5G licences. Symmetric allocation boosts indoor capacity but creates no competitive gap. ([Spectrum Tracker](#), 2026)

- **MVNO pressure building** — Industry body BABTO (including Neterra) is lobbying CRC to impose mandatory wholesale mobile access obligations, potentially tied to any future spectrum tender. Bulgaria remains the only EU market with zero operational MVNOs; no CRC decision imminent. ([Neterra](#), 2026)
- **Network quality — Vivacom leads** — Opensignal January 2026 report places Vivacom ahead on overall mobile network experience; A1 wins speed categories; Yettel wins availability and reliability. Three-way quality differentiation is emerging as the real competitive battleground. ([Opensignal](#), 2026-01)
- **Sector investment outpaces economy** — Telecoms investment and employment growing faster than the national average. Operators collectively earmarked BGN 1.1B for 5G; not in retrenchment mode. ([Novinite](#), 2026)

Outlook to Year-End

- **Yettel 5G acceleration** — e&'s capital injection (closed late 2024) expected to fund accelerated 5G standalone rollout through H2 2026. If Yettel closes the coverage gap on Vivacom, retail competition on network quality could re-intensify — watch for coverage claim announcements in Q3.
- **Second inflation-linked price round** — A further BGN 1–2 monthly increase across all operators is plausible in Q3 2026, following the established annual pattern. Would sustain ARPU growth but risks CRC enforcement action if timing is again coordinated; CRC investigation from early 2025 round is still open.
- **CRC wholesale/MVNO decision** — Any CRC ruling imposing open-access obligations — on new fibre infrastructure or tied to a spectrum tender — would be the most structurally disruptive event of the year. Direction of travel is slowly moving toward obligation; timing uncertain but watch H2 2026.

Sources

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